

renewal emerge as the needs that bind us with an iron necessity to the guarantees and all that they make it impossible for us to know. It is easy to deprecate Dubya and, apparently, to hold onto the idea that he's a temporary aberration. But the problem goes deeper. To revive a battle cry from the 1960s, insofar as one is wedded to any one of the guarantees one is part of the problem and not the solution. For the grandest function of the system of guarantees, as a whole and in each one of its parts, is to blind us to history.

And so to take up again the question stated previously, how did the situation now being created in Iraq come about? The next three sections constitute an attempt to answer that question by constructing for America a repressed history.

THE NUCLEAR UNCONSCIOUS

"... he begins to expand, an uncontainable light ... hero and horror, engineer and Ariadne consumed, molten inside the light of himself, the mad exploding of himself"

Thomas Pynchon, *Gravity's Rainbow*

To recapitulate historical facts that it took over 50 years to rescue from myth: the United States did not bomb Hiroshima and Nagasaki "to end the war and save countless lives." It did so for four reasons (and in the knowledge that a defeated Japan was pursuing terms of surrender through several diplomatic channels): (1) to avenge Pearl Harbor, (2) to justify the amount of money spent developing the bomb, (3) to create a laboratory whereby our scientific, medical, and military personnel could study its effects, and (4) to impress the Russians—and the world—with this opening salvo of the Cold War. In short, Hiroshima was the first act of global terrorism. That story couldn't be told, however, and still encounters strenuous resistance from most Americans, because it exposes too many of the guarantees we want to have about our nation and its actions in history.

Those actions also gave birth to another myth and another skewed history. The mythical story of the development of "the peaceful atom." No sooner were the tidings of the Nuclear Age broadcast to a terrified world than we heard promises of a nuclear Utopia. Through those promises a collective fantasy was created about the guarantees that the peaceful atom gave us about the *future*. Entire cities would have all their energy needs met for the cost of a nickel. Etc. Now 50 years later we find that we can't get rid of the nuclear waste we've